



GOVERNANCE DOCUMENT

Whistleblower Policy

International Society of Equity Analysts

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This document forms part of the official governance framework of the International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) and should be read together with the related documents listed above.

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1. Purpose

The International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) is committed to maintaining the highest standards of integrity, accountability, transparency, and ethical conduct across all aspects of its operations.

This Whistleblower Policy establishes a framework to encourage and protect individuals who, in good faith, report concerns regarding suspected misconduct, unethical behaviour, breaches of law, breaches of ISEA policies, professional standards violations, fraud, corruption, conflicts of interest, or conduct that may harm ISEA, its members, investors, or the broader equity analysis profession.

ISEA recognises that individuals who identify wrongdoing may face concerns regarding confidentiality, retaliation, or professional consequences. This Policy is designed to provide a safe, confidential, and fair process for raising concerns and ensuring that appropriate action is taken.

This Policy operates consistently with the **Ethics Policy**, **Conflict of Interest Policy**, **Complaints Policy**, **Disciplinary Policy**, and the ethical principles contained in the **Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct** ("Code").

2. Scope and Application

This Policy applies to:

- Governing Council members;
- Officers and executives;
- Committee members;
- Employees;
- Members (Student Members, Associate Members, Members and Fellows);
- Certification holders;
- Candidates;
- Volunteers;
- Contractors;
- Consultants;
- Education providers;
- Partners;
- Any person performing services for or representing ISEA.

A person making a disclosure under this Policy is referred to as a **Whistleblower**.

3. Purpose of Whistleblower Protection

ISEA seeks to create an environment where individuals are encouraged to raise legitimate concerns without fear of:

- Retaliation;
- Victimisation;
- Discrimination;
- Harassment;
- Professional disadvantage;
- Unfair treatment.

ISEA considers responsible reporting of wrongdoing to be an important contribution to maintaining professional standards and organisational integrity.

4. Matters That May Be Reported

A Whistleblower may raise concerns regarding actual, suspected, or potential misconduct, including:

4.1 Fraud and Financial Misconduct

Including:

- Fraudulent activity;
- Theft or misuse of ISEA resources;
- Financial misreporting;
- Improper financial transactions;
- Corruption or bribery.

4.2 Ethical and Professional Misconduct

Including:

- Breaches of the ISEA Ethics Policy;
- Breaches of the CFA Institute Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct;
- Misrepresentation of qualifications or certifications;
- Dishonest professional conduct;
- Research integrity concerns.

4.3 Conflicts of Interest

Including:

- Undisclosed conflicts;
- Improper personal benefit;
- Abuse of position;
- Failure to act independently.

4.4 Governance and Leadership Concerns

Including:

- Misconduct by Governing Council members, officers, or committee members;
- Abuse of authority;
- Breaches of fiduciary responsibilities;
- Failure of governance processes.

4.5 Legal and Regulatory Breaches

Including:

- Breaches of applicable laws;
- Regulatory misconduct;
- Conduct likely to cause harm to members, investors, or the public.

4.6 Other Serious Misconduct

Including conduct that may:

- Damage ISEA's reputation;
- Undermine professional standards;
- Compromise member trust;
- Harm the integrity of the equity analysis profession.

5. Matters Generally Not Covered

This Policy is not intended primarily for:

- General membership complaints;
- Service dissatisfaction;
- Personal disputes;
- Routine administrative matters.

Such matters may be addressed under the **Complaints Policy**.

However, a matter initially submitted as a complaint may be treated as a whistleblower disclosure where it involves serious misconduct or public interest concerns.

6. Good Faith Reporting

ISEA encourages individuals to report concerns honestly and responsibly.

A person does not need to prove that misconduct has occurred before making a disclosure. A reasonable belief that misconduct may have occurred is sufficient.

A Whistleblower should provide:

- A description of the concern;
- Relevant facts;
- Names of persons involved, where known;
- Supporting evidence or information;
- Any relevant dates or circumstances.

7. Protection Against Retaliation

ISEA prohibits retaliation against any person who:

- Makes a disclosure in good faith;
- Assists with an investigation;
- Provides information relating to suspected misconduct;
- Participates in a whistleblower process.

Retaliation includes:

- Threats;
- Harassment;
- Discrimination;
- Removal from opportunities;
- Unfair treatment;
- Professional disadvantage.

Any person engaging in retaliation may be subject to disciplinary action.

8. Confidentiality and Anonymity

ISEA will protect the confidentiality of Whistleblowers to the greatest extent reasonably possible.

Information relating to a disclosure will only be shared with persons who:

- Need the information to assess or investigate the matter;
- Are responsible for governance oversight;
- Are required by law to receive the information.

ISEA may accept anonymous disclosures where sufficient information is provided to allow meaningful assessment.

Where anonymity is maintained, ISEA may be limited in its ability to:

- Seek further information;
- Provide updates;
- Conduct a complete investigation.

9. Reporting Channels

Concerns may be reported through appropriate channels established by ISEA.

Reports may be submitted to:

- The Chairperson of the Audit, Risk and Compliance Committee;
- The Chairperson of the Ethics and Professional Standards Committee;
- The ISEA Governing Council Chairperson;
- An independent reporting channel designated by ISEA.

Where the concern relates to a particular person, the disclosure should be directed to a person independent of that individual.

10. Assessment of Disclosures

Upon receiving a disclosure, ISEA shall undertake an initial assessment to determine:

- Whether the matter falls within this Policy;
- Whether urgent action is required;
- Whether an investigation should commence;
- Whether another process is more appropriate.

Possible outcomes include:

- No further action;
- Referral to another ISEA process;
- Informal resolution;
- Formal investigation.

11. Investigation Process

Where an investigation is required, ISEA may:

- Appoint an investigator;
- Establish an independent review panel;
- Examine relevant documents;
- Interview relevant persons;
- Obtain expert advice;
- Consult professional advisers.

Investigations shall be conducted:

- Objectively;
- Confidentially;
- Fairly;
- Without predetermined conclusions.

12. Rights of Persons Named in Disclosures

Individuals who are the subject of a disclosure shall be treated fairly.

They shall generally be:

- Informed of allegations where appropriate;
- Given an opportunity to respond;
- Provided procedural fairness.

ISEA may delay notification where necessary to protect:

- Evidence;
- The integrity of the investigation;
- The confidentiality of the Whistleblower.

13. Investigation Outcomes

Following investigation, ISEA may determine that:

- The concern is unsubstantiated;
- Further monitoring is appropriate;
- Remedial action is required;
- Policy improvements are necessary;
- Disciplinary action should commence;
- External referral is appropriate.

Where appropriate, findings may be referred to:

- The Ethics and Professional Standards Committee;
- The Audit, Risk and Compliance Committee;
- The Governing Council;
- Regulators or authorities.

14. Responsibilities

14.1 Whistleblowers

Whistleblowers are expected to:

- Act honestly and in good faith;
- Provide accurate information;
- Maintain confidentiality where requested;
- Cooperate with reasonable investigation processes.

14.2 Governing Council

The Governing Council is responsible for:

- Ensuring appropriate whistleblower governance;
- Protecting organisational integrity;
- Overseeing significant matters.

14.3 Audit, Risk and Compliance Committee

The Audit, Risk and Compliance Committee shall:

- Oversee whistleblower arrangements;
- Monitor significant disclosures;
- Ensure appropriate investigation processes;

- Report material matters to the Governing Council.

14.4 Ethics and Professional Standards Committee

The Ethics and Professional Standards Committee shall:

- Address ethical misconduct matters;
- Consider professional standards breaches;
- Recommend disciplinary action where appropriate.

15. Malicious or False Reports

ISEA recognises that disclosures made in good faith should be protected even where concerns are ultimately unsubstantiated.

However, knowingly false, malicious, or deliberately misleading reports may constitute misconduct and may result in disciplinary action.

16. Records and Reporting

ISEA shall maintain appropriate records regarding:

- Disclosures received;
- Assessments conducted;
- Investigations undertaken;
- Outcomes achieved;
- Remedial actions implemented.

Material whistleblower matters shall be reported to the Governing Council while protecting confidentiality.

17. Relationship with Other ISEA Policies

This Policy should be read together with:

- Ethics Policy;
- Code;
- Conflict of Interest Policy;
- Complaints Policy;
- Disciplinary Policy;
- Privacy Policy;
- Risk Management Policy;
- Risk Management Framework.

18. Review and Continuous Improvement

The Audit, Risk & Compliance Committee shall periodically review this Policy to ensure alignment with:

- Applicable whistleblower laws;
- Governance best practices;
- Professional standards;
- Organisational developments.

The Committee shall recommend amendments to the Governing Council where appropriate.

19. Effective Date

This Whistleblower Policy takes effect on the date approved by the ISEA Governing Council.